

Problem #5: Japanese Compound Words (20 marks)

Solution:

Rendaku is a process that occurs in Japanese compounds wherein the initial voiceless obstruent of the second word becomes voiced:

Unvoiced		Voiced
k	→	g
s	→	z
t	→	d
h	→	b
ts	→	dz

Rendaku does not occur when:

- The second element of the compound contains a voiced obstruent in any position.
- The compound word means “X and Y”.

Assignment 1:

Japanese words	Compound word	Gloss	Meaning
wa + kasi	wagasi	Japanese + cake	Japanese cake
yama + kazi	yamakazi	mountain + fire	forest fire
juzu + tsunagi	juzutsunagi	rosary + sequence	roping together
yama + tera	yamadera	mountain + temple	mountain temple
ao + kawazu	aokawazu	green + frog	green frog
uwa + huta	uwabuta	top + lid	top lid
e + tako	edako	picture + kite	picture kite

Assignment 2:

For three-word compounds, say **XYZ**, one needs to first consider how the words are grouped semantically, i.e., whether it is **[X Y] Z** or **X [Y Z]**. The Rendaku rules for two-word compounds, as stated above are to be applied first to **[X Y]** or **[Y Z]** depending on the semantic grouping. And then the resultant compound is treated as a new word **XY** or **YZ**, which is then compounded with **Z** or **X** applying again the Rendaku rules for two-word compounds.

Japanese words	Compound Word	Gloss	Meaning
nise-sakura-dayori	nise-zakura-dayori (A)	[fake cherry-blossom] tidings	tidings of fake cherry-blossoms
nuri-hasi-hako	nuri-basi-bako (B)	[lacquered chopstick] box	box for lacquered chopsticks
nise-tanuki-siru	nise-danuki-ziru (C)	[pseudo tanuki] soup	soup made from pseudo tanuki
nise-tanuki-siru	nise-tanuki-ziru (D)	pseudo [tanuki soup]	tanuki soup that is not authentic
oya-ko-kenka	oya-ko-genka (E)	[parent child] quarrel	parent and child quarrel